

next film, the acclaimed *Black Friday*, two years to reach the screens because the TADA court felt that the film could not come out before the court's verdict. The twin blows drove Kashyap into a corkscrew of alcohol, cigarettes and depression not unlike Abhay Deol's human torch act in *Dev.D* from which he still hasn't recovered physically at least. It took *No Smoking*, out in 2007, to finally break the hoodoo though the John Abraham-starrer sank without a trace. The film offered more than a hint of Kashyap's Achilles' heel. Amit Khanna who once predicted that Kashyap would outlast his peers because he was so rooted in the world around him, is worried. "My only apprehension is that Anurag tends to get a bit carried away by the complexity of his own storytelling," he warns.

The release of *Black Friday* brought Kashyap international acclaim and a certain Boyle to his doorstep. Impressed by the docu-drama's gritty slum chases, the British director took advice on shooting in crowded places for *Slumdog Millionaire*.

Apart from a passion for cinema, also his blog's title, Kashyap has a dogged determination and a refusal to compromise. The late Goldie Anand, who was the Censor Board chief during the *Paanch* controversy, once fulminated: "I'm trying to help that boy, but he simply won't listen. He does not want to cut a single scene." Varma joked about Kashyap being someone who would break his head against a wall if he ever ran into one. Varma would of course merely walk around it and this is one reason Kashyap hates talking about his *Satya* director. Because he compromised.

Giving in is something Kashyap, a boy from small town Varanasi, says he will never do. Like most directors of his generation who routinely overdose on world cinema, he name drops Godard and de Sica but his points of reference are from within the industry. He is awestruck by Guru Dutt, *Pyaasa* and lyricist Sahir Ludhianvi. With Guru Dutt, Kashyap finally gets to come close to his Icarus-like idol. He has been writing the project 'very carefully' for the past one-and-a-half years, "because it is about a real person". He has two other writing projects, *Shor*, an urban love story being helmed by Kunal Kapoor

(Shashi Kapoor's son) and *Bombay Velvet*, a noir thriller. There is a big one on the horizon, *Doga*, based on the kitschy comic book series about a dog mask-wearing vigilante who prowls the streets of Mumbai with his dog army.

Part of the reason for his away-from-the-crowds appeal has been the fact that nothing is too irreverent for him. In *Hanuman Returns*, Kashyap's maiden foray into animation, which he made for his eight-year-old daughter Aaliyah, contemporised the monkey God into the world of computers and Google Earth. His dogged refusal to compromise on his vision has been another key factor in ensuring he will never get work easily. He split with his mentor Varma over creative differences. Kashyap now prefers working with rank outsiders, and has launched more talent than any other director of his generation (see box).

Here's the other side to Kashyap, the guy who is genuinely passionate about cinema and will go out of his way to help newcomers. Who travelled halfway across the country to attend an obscure film festival in Guwahati because he wants to be part of a nascent film culture. One who will translate someone else's dreams into celluloid: *Dev.D* was Abhay Deol's concept.

At a time when the tidal wave at the box-office has made strugglers out of showmen and turned mega banners like Yash Raj into shrinking icebergs, Kashyap's films are a new post-recessionary business model. Made on shoe-string budgets, they fly beneath the radar and hurt little if they lose, but, as in the case of *Dev.D*, hit the jackpot if they get it right. Most of the cast and crew, including Kashyap, appear in the film. So one of the Patna ke Presley singers is his assistant director, Koechlin's mother is the production art director of *Dev.D*.

The women in his films are strong, idealistic and have a mind of their own because 'he hates the girl next door'. "A woman who can stand up is the only one I can respect and talk to," he drawls. He now confesses to being in love with Koechlin, the bee-stung lipped French-Indian actor he introduced in *Dev.D* who has 'brought stability into his life'. But hold it, there's another woman in his life. His daughter who lives with ex-wife Aarti. "As long as I am the best papa in my daughter's eyes," he says, "I don't care about anything else." ■

Anurag's UNDERWORLD

The director is a launchpad for industry talent

KAY KAY MENON



Dependable character-actor, relaunched in *Black Friday*

RAJKUMAR GUPTA



Former assistant director, helmed the riveting *Aamir*

RAJEEV RAVI



Cinematographer from south who has lensed *Dev.D* and *Gulaal*

AARTI BAJAJ



Film editor who debuted in *Paanch*, has edited all his films since then